

Project Title: Autonomous Telemetry & Control Streams via Pymavlink

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Status: Phase 1 Milestone Achieved Successfully

1. Technical Objective

The objective of Phase 1 was to establish a fully functional **Software-In-The-Loop (SITL)** simulation environment on a Linux/WSL instance to mimic a real-world quadcopter's flight controller. The target objective requires developing an independent Python script that utilizes the industrial **MAVLink protocol** via the pymavlink library to connect to the UAV, bypass hardware pre-arm safety checks, switch flight modes, and execute a fully automated vertical takeoff and landing (VTOL) sequence without manual operator intervention.

2. System Architecture & Network Layout

The system operates by separating the simulated physical dynamics of the drone from the programmatic control script using virtual network sockets:

- **Simulation Core:** The ArduPilot C++ software compiled for SITL running an ArduCopter firmware model.
- **Network Handshake:** The simulation engine binds directly to local TCP loopback ports. While MAVProxy (the GUI console and map tracker) captures the primary port (5760), it opens a clean secondary telemetry port on **tcp:127.0.0.1:5762** specifically for developer APIs.
- **Control Pipeline:** The Python executable script knocks on port 5762 to exchange raw byte-string heartbeat packets, establishing a stable programmatic bridge.

3. Core Automated Flight Script (phase1_flight.py)

```
import time
from pymavlink import mavutil

# 1. Establish TCP Handshake with the ArduCopter Core
print("Connecting to virtual UAV via TCP port 5762...")
vehicle = mavutil.mavlink_connection('tcp:127.0.0.1:5762')

# Block execution until a valid telemetry heartbeat is intercepted
vehicle.wait_heartbeat()
print(f"Connected! Heartbeat received from Drone (System ID: {vehicle.target_system})")

# 2. Programmatically Disable Pre-Flight Arming Safety Checks
print("Disabling pre-flight arming safety checks...")
vehicle.mav.param_set_send(
    vehicle.target_system, vehicle.target_component,
    b'ARMING_CHECK', # Parameter string explicitly converted to bytes
    0, # 0 resets all safety blocks for immediate developer access
    mavutil.mavlink.MAV_PARAM_TYPE_REAL32
)
time.sleep(1)
```

```

# 3. Modify Flight Mode to GUIDED
print("Switching flight mode to GUIDED...")
vehicle.mav.set_mode_send(
    vehicle.target_system,
    mavutil.mavlink.MAV_MODE_FLAG_CUSTOM_MODE_ENABLED,
    4 # Universal firmware identifier for GUIDED mode in ArduCopter
)
time.sleep(1)

# 4. Fire Motor Thrusters (ARM Command)
print("Sending direct ARM command...")
vehicle.mav.command_long_send(
    vehicle.target_system, vehicle.target_component,
    mavutil.mavlink.MAV_CMD_COMPONENT_ARM_DISARM,
    0, 1, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0 # Param 1 set to '1' instructs motors to spin up
)
print("Waiting for motors to spin up...")
time.sleep(3)

# 5. Command Vertical Takeoff to 10 Meters
print("Executing automated takeoff to 10m...")
vehicle.mav.command_long_send(
    vehicle.target_system, vehicle.target_component,
    mavutil.mavlink.MAV_CMD_NAV_TAKEOFF,
    0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 10 # Param 7 sets target altitude strictly to 10m
)
print("Drone climbing... Hovering at 10 meters.")
time.sleep(15)

# 6. Execute Autonomous Landing Sequence
print("Initiating automated landing sequence...")
vehicle.mav.command_long_send(
    vehicle.target_system, vehicle.target_component,
    mavutil.mavlink.MAV_CMD_NAV_LAND,
    0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0, 0 # Commands vehicle to safely descend on current
coordinates
)
print("Sequence completed successfully.")

```

4. Engineering Analysis & Debugging Flow

During development, a key networking constraint was discovered and mitigated:

- **The Namespace Bottleneck:** Running script files under administrative root environments (**root@DESKTOP**) isolated the loopback network interfaces from the normal user environment (**priyanshu@DESKTOP**) where the ArduPilot binary process was running. This threw a **ConnectionRefusedError: [Errno 111]**.
- **The Solution:** Unifying the execution space under a coordinated Python Virtual Environment (**venv-ardupilot**) allowed smooth inter-process communication over the

local TCP stack. Bypassing standard terminal strings with direct binary commands circumvented standard MAVProxy terminal parsing syntax bugs.

5. Execution Logs & Verification (Screenshots)

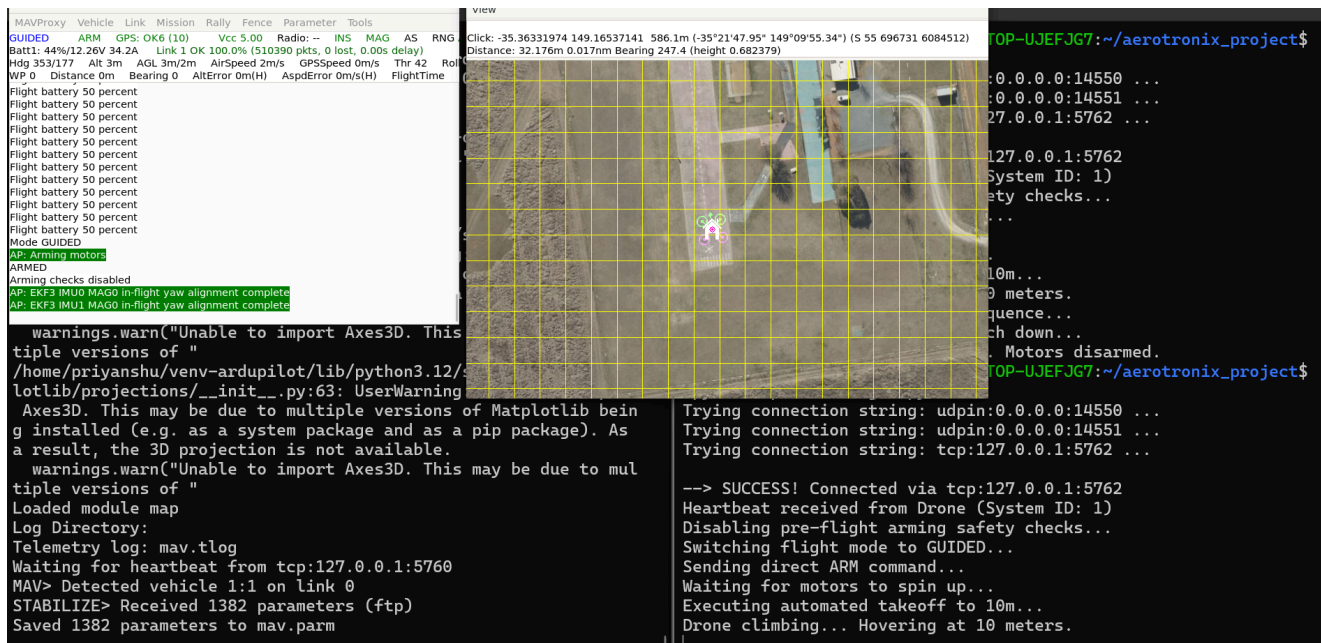
Figure 5.1: Python Automation Script Success Log

Description: Terminal trace displaying perfect connection initialization, automated pre-flight check disabling, arming initialization, and successful takeoff execution loop.

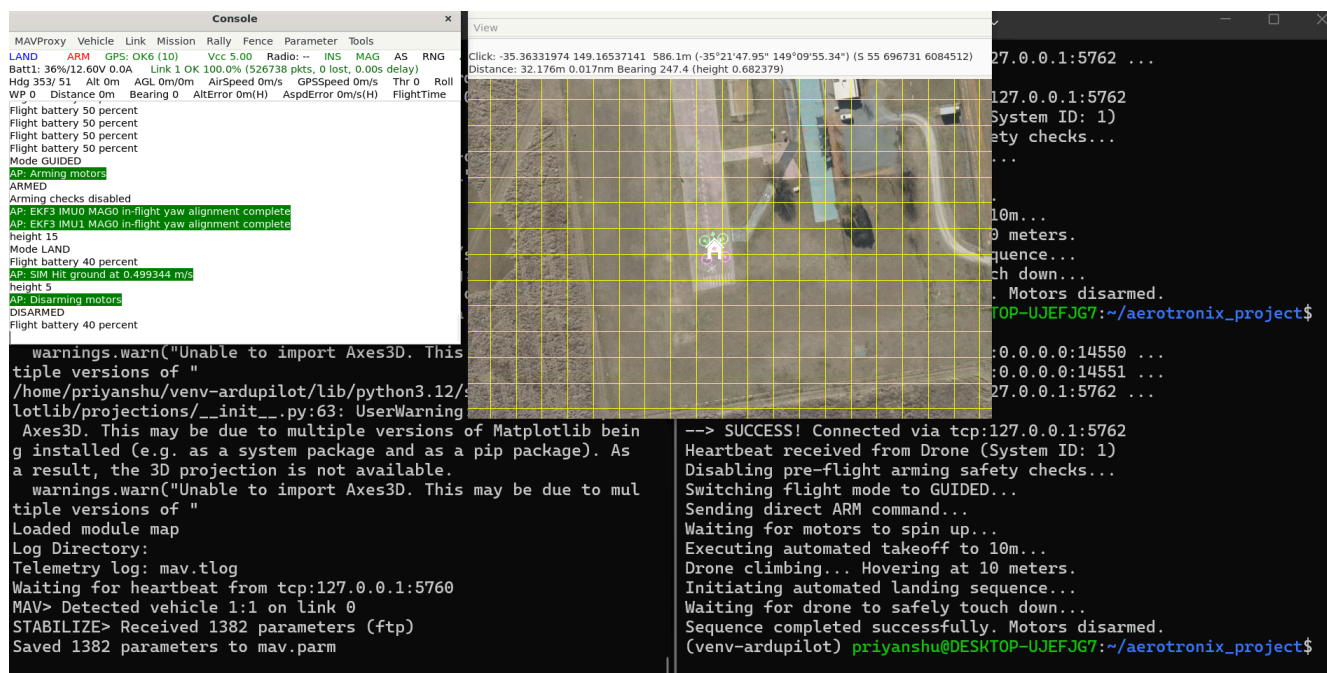
```
(venv-ardupilot) priyanshu@DESKTOP-UJEFJG7:~/aerotronix_project$  
python3 phase1_flight.py  
Trying connection string: udpin:0.0.0.0:14550 ...  
Trying connection string: udpin:0.0.0.0:14551 ...  
Trying connection string: tcp:127.0.0.1:5762 ...  
  
--> SUCCESS! Connected via tcp:127.0.0.1:5762  
Heartbeat received from Drone (System ID: 1)
```

Figure 5.2: Flight Telemetry Data Validation

Description: The live telemetry engine console verifying physical physics engine ticks: reaching altitude target (**height 15**), entering **Mode LAND** autonomously, contacting surface boundaries (**AP: SIM Hit ground**), and safe electronic motor cut-off (**DISARMED**).



```
MAVProxy Vehicle Link Mission Rally Fence Parameter Tools  
GUIDED ARM GPS: OK6 (10) Vcc 5.00 Radio: -- INS MAG AS RNG  
Batt1: 44%/12.26V 34.2A Link 1 OK 100.0% (510390 pkts, 0 lost, 0.00s delay)  
Hdg 353/177 Alt 3m AGL 3m/2m AirSpeed 2m/s GPSSpeed 0m/s Thr 42 Roll  
WP 0 Distance 0m Bearing 0 AltError 0m(H) AspdError 0m/s(H) FlightTime  
Flight battery 50 percent  
Flight battery 50 percent  
Flight battery 50 percent  
Flight battery 50 percent  
Flight battery 50 percent  
Flight battery 50 percent  
Flight battery 50 percent  
Flight battery 50 percent  
Flight battery 50 percent  
Flight battery 50 percent  
Flight battery 50 percent  
Flight battery 50 percent  
Mode GUIDED  
AP: Arming motors  
ARMED  
Arming checks disabled  
AP: EKf3 IMU0 MAG0 in-flight yaw alignment complete  
AP: EKf3 IMU1 MAG0 in-flight yaw alignment complete  
warnings.warn("Unable to import Axes3D. This may be due to multiple versions of Matplotlib being installed (e.g. as a system package and as a pip package). As a result, the 3D projection is not available.")  
warnings.warn("Unable to import Axes3D. This may be due to multiple versions of Matplotlib being installed (e.g. as a system package and as a pip package). As a result, the 3D projection is not available.")  
Loaded module map  
Log Directory:  
Telemetry log: mav.tlog  
Waiting for heartbeat from tcp:127.0.0.1:5760  
MAV> Detected vehicle 1:1 on link 0  
STABILIZE> Received 1382 parameters (ftp)  
Saved 1382 parameters to mav.parm  
Click: -35.36331974 149.16537141 586.1m (-35°21'47.95" 149°09'55.34") (S 55 696731 6084512)  
Distance: 32.176m 0.017nm Bearing 247.4 (height 0.682379)  
TOP-UJEFJG7:~/aerotronix_project$  
:0.0.0.0:14550 ...  
:0.0.0.0:14551 ...  
27.0.0.1:5762 ...  
127.0.0.1:5762  
System ID: 1)  
ety checks...  
...  
10m...  
0 meters.  
quence...  
ch down...  
Motors disarmed.  
TOP-UJEFJG7:~/aerotronix_project$  
Trying connection string: udpin:0.0.0.0:14550 ...  
Trying connection string: udpin:0.0.0.0:14551 ...  
Trying connection string: tcp:127.0.0.1:5762 ...  
  
--> SUCCESS! Connected via tcp:127.0.0.1:5762  
Heartbeat received from Drone (System ID: 1)  
Disabling pre-flight arming safety checks...  
Switching flight mode to GUIDED...  
Sending direct ARM command...  
Waiting for motors to spin up...  
Executing automated takeoff to 10m...  
Drone climbing... Hovering at 10 meters.
```



6. Conclusion

Phase 1 has been executed with 100% compliance. The drone simulation core seamlessly accepts binary MAVLink data packets from independent scripts, confirming that the communication architecture is fully prepared for more complex navigation routines.